

So you're thinking about law

The short version — written for you, not about you.

Everything that matters, none of the bits written for your parents.

We scored twenty-seven careers on how exposed they are to AI. Law came out with the widest internal split of any licensed profession we measured.

A trial lawyer scores 4.5 out of 10. A junior associate doing document review scores 7.9.

Same degree. Same bar exam. Sometimes the same firm.

The 60-second version

- Law isn't dying. Legal employment just hit a ten-year high.
 - **But the way in has narrowed sharply.** Only 38% of new associates now come straight from law school, down from 46% two years ago.
 - The work AI took is exactly the work junior lawyers used to learn on.
 - The real risk isn't automation. It's the debt.
 - There's one skill nobody is teaching yet, and it matters more in law than almost anywhere.
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What actually happened

Firms automated first-pass document review, contract analysis, legal research and first-draft memos.

That list happens to be an almost complete description of what a first-year associate did in 2019.

So the profession is fine — better than fine, revenues are at records — but the work you'd have learned on has largely gone, and firms are hiring experienced lawyers laterally instead of training new ones.

A healthy profession with a narrowing entrance isn't a contradiction. It's the defining shape of this moment, and law is where it's clearest.

Why the top of the profession is safe

Two reasons, and they're both durable.

Only a barred lawyer can appear in court, sign advice, or be professionally answerable when it goes wrong. That's written in law, and law changes at the speed of politics rather than

technology.

And advocacy is adversarial. You're up against someone actively trying to be unpredictable. That's a completely different problem from complexity — a complicated thing can be learned, but an opponent changes when you learn them. Nothing in AI handles that well.

The thing worth actually understanding

Here's the bit that took us longest to see, and it generalises well beyond law.

Your bar card protects specific acts, not you as a person.

It protects the courtroom appearance. It protects the signed advice. It does not protect reading forty thousand documents — nothing in any statute says a human has to do that. So the moment the technology was good enough, that work went.

Compare nursing. A nursing licence does something a law licence doesn't: it *mandates the training hours*. You legally cannot qualify without supervised clinical practice, so the way in is protected by the same rule that protects the job.

Law reserves the courtroom and the signature, and leaves the apprenticeship completely exposed.

So when you look at any career, don't just ask whether there's a licence. Ask what it actually reserves — and whether it reserves the training too.

The scores

TRACK	SCORE
Trial litigator	4.5
Regulatory & compliance counsel	5.0
In-house counsel	5.2
Corporate / transactional	6.3
Junior associate / doc review	7.9

The pattern: **exposure falls as personal accountability rises.** The further you are from being the one who answers for the outcome, the more exposed you are.

Which is uncomfortable, because you can't start with accountability. It has to be earned — and the traditional way of earning it is the part that's been compressed.

The skill nobody is teaching

Knowing when the AI is wrong.

This matters more in law than almost anywhere, and the evidence is blunt: **researchers have now documented around 1,600 court cases worldwide where lawyers filed AI-generated citations to cases that don't exist.** Up from about 200 a year earlier.

Confidently written, properly formatted, entirely fictional. The first one in 2023 drew a \$5,000 fine. By 2026 courts were fining attorneys \$15,000 each, suspending them, and cancelling trials over it.

Every single case has the same root cause: **a lawyer signed a citation they hadn't read.**

You can only catch that if you know the law well enough yourself. Which means the dull foundational years matter *more*, not less.

And here's your opening. Firms are rebuilding what a first-year does — directing AI through research and drafting, then checking and communicating the result. Some now test for it in final-round interviews.

Most working lawyers are figuring this out alone. You'd arrive as **part of the first group who never had to unlearn anything** — and in a profession where advancement is famously about time served, that's one dimension where being new is an advantage.

One caution, since school will have told you the opposite. Using AI to skip the work leaves you weaker, and in law that eventually becomes a negligence problem rather than a grades problem. But *understanding* AI is a different thing entirely. That was never cheating.

The part we won't soften

The debt is the real risk here, not the robots.

And there's something about law salaries almost nobody explains: **they're bimodal.** Around half of graduates start between \$60,000 and \$85,000. About a quarter start between \$215,000 and

\$225,000. Almost nobody lands in the middle.

Which means the "average starting salary" a law school quotes you describes essentially no real graduate. You'll be in one group or the other, and which one depends heavily on where you study.

Georgetown tracked earnings *after* debt payments four years out: \$72,000 median across all law graduates — but under \$55,000 at 33 schools, and over \$200,000 at seven. That's a bigger spread than you'll find in almost any other profession.

Also true: billable-hour culture is demanding through your twenties and thirties.

And the wellbeing picture is documented rather than rumoured. The ABA surveyed nearly 13,000 lawyers: 21% screened positive for problematic drinking, 28% for depression, 19% for anxiety. The risk was highest among junior lawyers, not senior ones — which overturned what the profession had assumed. Worth knowing before you go in rather than after.

And one genuinely open question. Some people argue the firms are making a mistake — that cutting junior hiring is self-defeating, because no juniors today means no seniors in ten years, and they'll be forced to reverse it. The logic is sound. The hiring data has gone the other way for three years anyway. We don't know which wins, and we'll say so when it becomes clear.

Does this actually sound like you?

Law tends to suit people who:

- Enjoy argument as a **craft**, not as conflict — that distinction matters more here than anywhere
- Are **precise by temperament**. Law rewards exactness and punishes approximation.
- Can hold the **opposing view** in mind clearly enough to argue against it
- Can be **wrong in public** — corrected by judges, opponents and colleagues, for a whole career

It's harder if you avoid conflict, need certainty and closure, want predictable hours early on, or are mostly being carried along by status or someone else's expectation. That last group is heavily over-represented among people who leave.

If you change your mind

You're not stuck. Law is unusually portable as a way of thinking — policy, government, business leadership, compliance, risk, legal technology, journalism, dispute resolution.

Same catch as everywhere else: **the further a role sits from being personally answerable for something, the higher its exposure climbs.**

What actually matters when picking a school

More than the ranking, and more than anything else here:

- **Where do graduates actually work in year one — and doing what?** Not "employed." Not "in the legal sector." Practising.
- Real advocacy and clinic experience, not just lectures
- Whether they teach you to use legal AI tools *and* verify them
- **Total cost against the median first-job salary for that school's graduates** — not the national average

And check whether apprenticeship or earn-while-you-qualify routes exist where you are. They're expanding while the traditional route narrows, and they don't come with the debt.

Two things worth doing

Sit in on a court hearing. Public galleries are open, it costs nothing, and an afternoon will tell you more about whether advocacy suits you than a year of thinking about it.

Then find a lawyer and ask properly. Not a family friend who'll be nice about it. Ask: *what are the trainees on your team doing, and how is that different from when you started?*

And one question for yourself. Do you want law, or do you want what law is made of?

People are drawn to it for different reasons — advocacy, precision, argument, helping people in trouble, and sometimes status. Those point in genuinely different directions, and **some of them are cheaper and faster to reach.**

If you want to go further — three things worth twenty minutes

- Senior lawyers lead the new hiring boom — read this one first. It's the entry-path problem in plain numbers.
 - AI is reshaping the entry-level pipeline in law, finance and consulting — the same thing happening in three professions at once, which tells you it's structural rather than a legal quirk.
 - Will AI replace lawyers? The 2026 data — this one argues against our score. Worth reading precisely for that.
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There's a longer version behind this — full scores by track, how they were worked out, the honest downsides, what to ask a law school, and where we might be wrong. Your parents have it.